

Nora N. Khan

ARCHIVE

GRANT ALLOCATED \$12,500

One-Sentence Description

Recovering how artistic research collectives built epistemic holding environments, and what their overlooked methods offer for better research cultures.

Proposed Project

Nora Khan is reviving the epistemological models generated by forgotten collectives, through archival visits, oral interviews, and essay writing. Nora is specifically interested in identifying replicable elements of organizational design that hold a generative space for the uncertainty and ambiguity carried by visionary knowledge production.

Collectives under Nora's investigation include the Detroit Geographic Expedition and Institute, Gene Youngblood's Intermedia columns in the LA Free Press, KUNCI Study Forum, and the Living Midnight Narrative Outfit. Each collective, dating back to the late 60s (DGEI), reveals a mode of operation that reexamines fundamental epistemic virtues: challenging the premise of neutral scientific observation, practicing networked cognition (predating computational frameworks), formalizing "epistemic humility" as a research method, and using speculative narrative as system methodology.

With Revival's funding, Nora will produce a sequence of 3-4 long-form essays tracing specific mechanisms of knowledge transmission from the collectives she studies. Essays will be developed in dialogue with scientists, science historians, and metascience researchers who can extend the transmission claims. These essays will be distributed over influential philosophy and art platforms (Noema, or e-flux) to reach a wide audience.

Revival Relevance

Nora is resurfacing collectives and their activities from the 60s to offer renewed perspectives on epistemic cultures. Today's metascience discourse largely constitutes discussions on how to improve science funding, research and publication. Many perspectives remain to be examined along studying the nature of knowledge production, and the environmental and organizational variables that facilitate breakthrough inquiry. Nora Khan, coming from the forefront of art and theory writing, has been writing extensively on the complex dynamics of artist research, technological mediation, and knowledge production.

Nora has identified intriguing collectives from the 60s that performed research activities challenging the methodological norms of making natural knowledge. Through her archival recovery, interview and writing, Nora will trace how these research collectives functioned as epistemic holding environments, and trace the specific scientific literature from each collective's influence. Nora anticipates these methodological foundations to be tied to later developments in simulation science, complexity theory, systems design and philosophy of technology. She also identifies an influence on participatory GIS and even biodiversity policy that was largely uncited.

Wendi's Notes

1. Nora has already been an influential thinker, critic and writer in art and technology for more than a decade.

Nora has been writing and thinking at the forefront of art and technology. Her 2015 essay [“Towards a Poetics of Artificial Superintelligence”](#) has widely cited and taught in art writing; her 2019 book *Seeing, Naming, Knowing* focused on machine vision and generative image production; she is set to publish a monograph on *AI Art and the Stakes for Art Criticism* in early 2027. Her writings on artists engaging with technologies, and related reflections on the knowledge economy of art and theory, have appeared in just about every major art and culture magazines and institutions. As a curator, she has co-curated the Biennale de L'Image en Mouvement 2024, *A Cosmic Movie Camera*, and the *Manual Override* (2020) at The Shed in New York City.

As a thinker, Nora has been ahead of the curve in identifying new image cultures shaped by technological changes, but going underneath that in investigating the structural shifts that generate the new image cultures.

2. Nora's project will offer an overlooked and important angle on the metascience discourse.

The metascience discourse has been filled with voices trained in science, engineering and economics. A core part of Revival Fund's mission is to facilitate cross-pollination of ideas through introducing perspectives from one disciplinary culture to another. I am particularly interested in supporting Nora's project, due to her synergistic research on modes of knowledge production and epistemic virtues, and the Analogue team's connection to science philanthropy, tech policy, the progress movement and the metascience community.

3. Nora's sustained interest in epistemology-at-large guarantees a holistic, grounded work.

A major theme underlying Nora's career in theory, curation and writing is on artists' role and potential impact in the shifting epistemic culture shaped by technological changes. I am excited to see what Nora will surface from the archives for the Revival project. She is in touch with the archivists for the corresponding archives, and has already published critical essays engaging with the activities from two of the collectives.

Nora will be working towards publishing a book from this research, and the grant provides a substantial launchpad for her to dive into a significant new research project that will formalize into curatorial methodology.